

The Long Return

Tadej Pogacar's fifth Tour de France asks what it means to choose the same difficult road after the world has already called you great.

BY THE PHILOSOPHY OF NOW

A practical reflection on attention, effort and enough

“The achievement is not only the summit. It is the willingness to prepare for another ascent after the applause has faded.”

On Sunday in Paris, after three weeks of heat, mountains and managed suffering, Tadej Pogacar rode into the final stage of the Tour de France in yellow. The crowd saw the familiar signs: the jersey, the bike, the sealed expression of a rider close to a finish. By the time the race ended, the 27-year-old Slovenian had won his fifth Tour, joining the small company of Eddy Merckx, Jacques Anquetil, Bernard Hinault and Miguel Indurain. A record can make an achievement look like a number. The road that produced it was never numerical.

What was remarkable in reporting from Paris was not merely the margin - six minutes and 26 seconds over Remco Evenepoel, according to the Associated Press - but the shape of the performance. Pogacar attacked in the mountains, won stages, and carried himself with the composed exactness that long races demand. It is tempting to convert such a performance into a simple moral: talent wins. But talent is the least useful thing to imitate. The more human lesson is that a person can return, again and again, to a discipline that has stopped being novel.

That is a strange challenge. We often imagine that success removes the need for effort. The promotion should end the proving; the finished degree should retire the doubt; the fifth championship should excuse a person from beginning once more. Yet the achievements that last are often made of a less glamorous decision: to keep meeting the ordinary conditions of the work. Sleep. Training. Study. Repair. A hard conversation held without performance. The unphotographed morning in which nobody is handing out a yellow jersey.

THE TENSION

There is a tension in every accomplished life between arrival and return. Arrival feels deserved. Return can feel almost insulting: surely one has earned the right to stop carrying the same weight. But a craft, a friendship, a body, or a community does not stay alive because of the certificate on the wall. It stays alive because someone returns to it. To say this is not to make a virtue of endless striving. Rest is not failure, and exhaustion is not proof of seriousness. Professional cycling, like many elite pursuits, should make us wary of turning human beings into engines for our inspiration. A victory is not a moral entitlement, and spectators do not know the private cost of another person's discipline. The point is gentler. When we choose to continue, the question is not whether we can endure more. It is whether this return still serves something we can honestly call ours.

A LENS FROM CAMUS

Albert Camus gave philosophy one of its most durable images: Sisyphus pushing his stone uphill, only to watch it roll back down. The image is usually summoned for futile work, but Camus's provocation was sharper. He asked us to imagine Sisyphus happy - not because the task becomes easy, but because the man sees it clearly and does not surrender the meaning of his effort to the gods who assigned it.

That is not a command to enjoy every repetition. It is an invitation to distinguish a chosen burden from an imposed one. Pogacar cannot make the Tour's roads shorter by wishing. He can decide what kind of rider he is while riding them. The rest of us face smaller hills, but the same distinction appears. We cannot control whether an inbox refills, a child wakes in the night, a market shifts, or a loved one needs us again. We can ask whether our way of returning expresses care, fear, vanity, habit - or a value we would recognize in daylight.

THE ORDINARY ROAD

There is a practical use for this thought. Before repeating an effort, pause long enough to name it. "I am answering this because I want to be reliable." "I am practicing because I want to learn, not merely to look competent." "I am taking a walk because my body is not an obstacle to my real life; it is where that life occurs." Naming the reason does not make chores charming. It keeps repetition from becoming anonymous.

Then make the return proportionate. The heroic version of discipline is easy to admire and difficult to sustain. A smaller return - twenty focused minutes, one honest apology, a meal cooked rather than optimized - often carries more truth than an extravagant burst of resolve. We need not ride another Tour. We need a rhythm that leaves enough of us alive to come back tomorrow.

Pogacar's fifth title will sit in history as a record. But records are only the public trace of private repetition. The day after any milestone, the road is still there, not asking whether we are famous enough to travel it, but whether we know why we are setting out.

SOURCES NOTE

Associated Press, "Tadej Pogacar confirms status as a cycling great with record-equaling fifth Tour de France title" (26 July 2026). Used for the result, margin and race context.

Sky Sports, "Pogacar wins record-equalling fifth title" (26 July 2026). Cross-check for the five-title milestone and final stage.

What is one difficult thing in your life that deserves a deliberate return - and what is one that you are finally allowed to put down?